Verb Patterns

I enjoy **going**. I decided **to go**. She made me **go**.



How to use this guide

This guide is for **self-study**. You do not need to submit anything. Read it in order, do the practice, and check your answers at the end. It takes about **60 minutes**.

Part	What you will do	Time
1	Understand what a verb pattern is	10 min
2	Learn the 6 patterns (one at a time)	25 min
3	Avoid 4 common mistakes	5 min
4	Practice + check your answers	20 min

By the end of this guide, you will be able to…

- recognize which form a verb needs after it: **-ING**, **TO + verb** or the **base verb**;
- use the most common verbs of each pattern correctly when you speak and write;
- explain how the meaning changes with **remember, forget, try, stop** and **regret**.

PART 1 What is a verb pattern?

The idea

Sometimes two verbs go together in the same sentence. **The first verb decides the form of the second verb.** That combination is called a **verb pattern**.

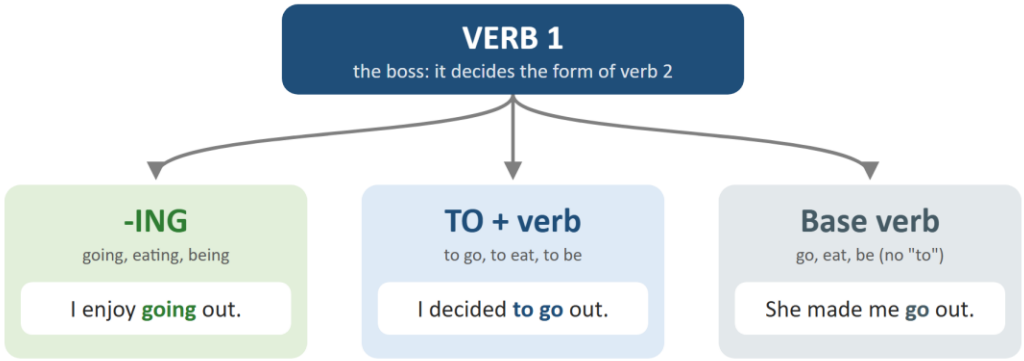
I	enjoy	dancing.
subject	VERB 1: the "boss"	VERB 2: follows the boss

✓ I enjoy **dancing**. ✗ I enjoy to dance.

Enjoy is the boss, and it always wants **-ING** after it.

The three forms of verb 2

Verb 2 can only take one of these three forms: the **-ING form** (gerund), **TO + verb** (to-infinitive) or the **base verb**.



Why is this difficult for Spanish speakers?

In Spanish, verb 2 is almost always the infinitive (**-ar, -er, -ir**). In English, it changes depending on verb 1:

Spanish	English
Disfruto **bailar**.	I enjoy **dancing**.
Decidí **viajar**.	I decided **to travel**.
Me hizo **llorar**.	She made me **cry**.

How to learn them

> **There is no magic rule.** Learn each verb together with its partner, like a package:
> not just **enjoy** → but **enjoy + -ING** not just **decide** → but **decide + TO**
> **Negative?** Put **not** before verb 2: I decided **not to go**. / I regret **not studying**.

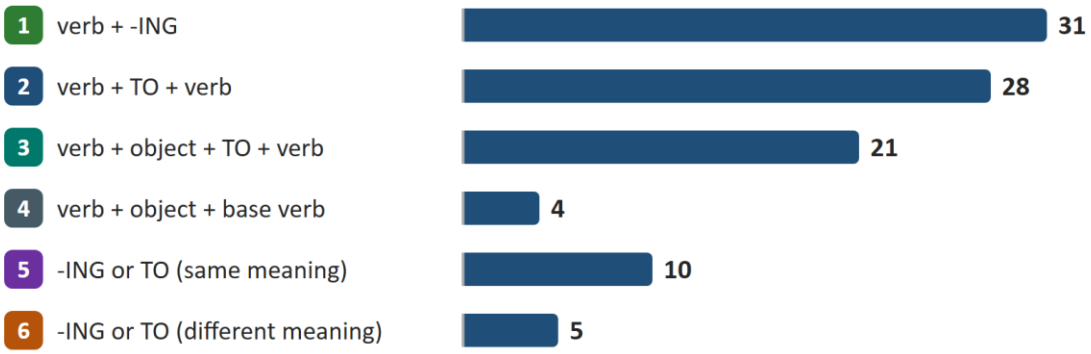
PART 2 The 6 verb patterns

Here is the **map** of everything you will learn. Then we look at each pattern, one by one.

#	Pattern	Example
1	**VERB + -ING**	I enjoy **going** to the park.
2	**VERB + TO + VERB**	They decided **to buy** a new car.
3	**VERB + OBJECT + TO + VERB**	The coach told **me to be** on time.
4	**VERB + OBJECT + BASE VERB**	She made **me watch** her favorite movie.
5	**VERB + -ING or TO (same meaning)**	I like **swimming**. = I like **to swim**.
6	**VERB + -ING or TO (different meaning)**	I stopped **to help** her. ≠ I stopped **helping** her.

How many verbs are in each pattern?

Patterns 1, 2 and 3 are the long lists. Study a few verbs every day.



Number of verbs in the "Verbs to learn" lists of this guide.

1

PATTERN 1

VERB + -ING



verb 1 + **verb-ING**

- I enjoy **going** to the park with my niece.
- He admitted **stealing** the money.
- Learning a language involves **studying** a little every day.

VERBS TO LEARN

admit	discuss	imagine	practice
anticipate	dislike	involve	quit
apologize for	dread	keep	recommend
avoid	enjoy	look forward to*	resume
be used to*	fancy	mention	risk
can't help	feel like	mind	suggest
consider	finish	miss	accuse sb of
deny	go (go swimming)	postpone	

Bonus rule: after a **preposition** (about, of, for, in, on, from…) the verb is **always -ING**: She worries about **failing**. / He insisted on **paying**. / Thanks for **helping** me.

* **Careful with "to"!** In **look forward to** and **be used to**, "to" is a preposition, so -ING follows: I look forward to **meeting** you. / I'm used to **working** at night.

2 PATTERN 2
VERB + TO + VERB



verb 1 + **to + verb**

- They decided **to buy** a new car.
- I can't afford **to travel** this year.
- We agreed **not to tell** anyone.

VERBS TO LEARN

afford	expect	offer	volunteer
agree	fail	plan	wait
ask	hope	pretend	want
attempt	learn	promise	would like
choose	manage	refuse	would love
decide	mean	struggle	would hate
deserve	need	threaten	would prefer

3 PATTERN 3
VERB + OBJECT + TO + VERB



verb 1 + **object** + **(not) to + verb**

The object (me, you, him, her, us, them, the students…) is the person who does verb 2.

- The coach told **me** **not to be** late for training.
- They encouraged **the students** **not to give up**.
- My parents want **me** **to study** medicine.

VERBS TO LEARN

advise	expect	permit	urge
allow	forbid	persuade	want
ask	force	remind	warn
beg	hire	require	
convince	invite	teach	
encourage	order	tell	

Spanish trap: "Quiero **que tú vengas**" is NOT "I want that you come". In English: I want **you** **to come**.

4 PATTERN 4
VERB + OBJECT + BASE VERB

verb 1 + **object** + **base verb** (no "to"!)

- She made **me** **watch** her favorite movie.
- They made **him** **apologize** to the class.
- She didn't let **me** **open** the window.
- Can you help **me** **(to) solve** this puzzle? (help: with or without "to")



VERBS TO LEARN

make	let	help (+ to)	would rather*

* **Would rather** also takes the base verb, but **without an object**: I would rather **stay** home tonight.

5 PATTERN 5
VERB + -ING or TO (same meaning)

verb 1 + **verb-ING** or **to + verb** → same meaning

- I like **swimming**. = I like **to swim**.
- It started **raining**. = It started **to rain**.



VERBS TO LEARN

like	prefer	continue	propose
love	begin	can't bear	
hate	start	can't stand	

Careful: with **would** it is only TO: I like **dancing**. but I would like **to dance** tonight.

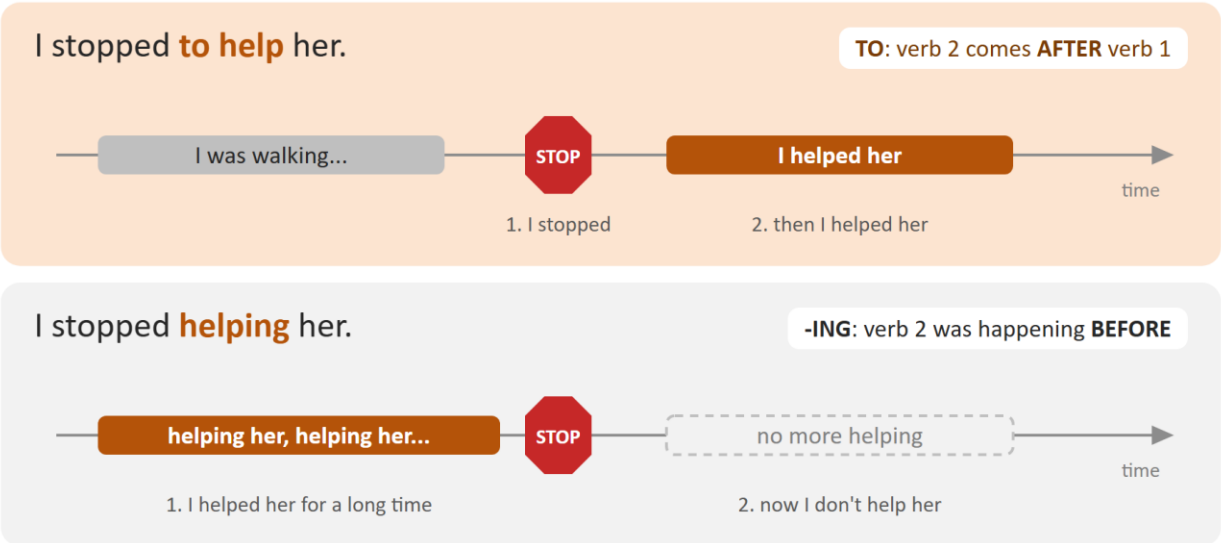
6 PATTERN 6
VERB + -ING or TO (different meaning)

verb 1 + **verb-ING** or **to + verb** → different meaning!

Only **5 verbs** to learn here, but they are important. Compare:

Verb	+ TO + verb	+ -ING
remember	Don't forget to do it (future). Remember **to turn off** the lights when you leave.	Have a memory of the past. I remember **turning off** the lights. I'm sure!
forget	Not do something you had to do. He forgot **to send** the email. (He didn't send it.)	Lose a memory (usually: never forget). I'll never forget **visiting** Cartagena.
try	Make an effort (it's difficult). I tried **to open** the window, but it was locked.	Experiment to solve a problem. It's hot. Try **opening** the window.
stop	Pause one action to do another. She stopped **to drink** some water.	Finish an action completely. He stopped **watching** TV to study.
regret	Be sorry to give bad news (formal). We regret **to inform** you that…	Feel sorry about the past. She regrets **telling** him her secret.

Shortcut: TO → verb 2 happens **after** verb 1 (it is in the future). -ING → verb 2 happened **before** or was already happening. **Exception: try.**



PART 3 4 common mistakes

These are the mistakes Spanish speakers make most often. Read the ✗ and the ✓.

	✗ Wrong	✓ Correct
1. "que" sentences	I want that you help me.	I want **you** **to help** me.
2. Translating the Spanish infinitive	I enjoy to cook.	I enjoy **cooking**.
3. "to" that is a preposition	I look forward to see you.	I look forward to **seeing** you.
4. "to" after make / let	My boss made me to work late.	My boss made me **work** late.

PART 4 Practice

Do the exercises **without looking** at Part 2 first. Then check your answers on the last page.

A. -ING, TO or both?

Write each verb in the correct column.

> **enjoy, decide, love, avoid, refuse, finish, hope, start, keep, afford**

+ -ING only	+ TO only	Both (-ING or TO)

B. Choose the correct option

Read the text about human rights and circle the correct option.

> Everyone deserves **(1) to live / living** with dignity. In 1948, the United Nations adopted the Universal Declaration of Human Rights, and since then it has encouraged governments **(2) to protect / protecting** the freedom of all people. However, millions of people still can't afford **(3) to go / going** to school or see a doctor. Some governments deny **(4) to violate / violating** human rights, but brave journalists keep **(5) to report / reporting** the truth. Human rights organizations also try to persuade citizens **(6) to speak / speaking** up. If you want to help, consider **(7) to volunteer / volunteering** for a local organization. And remember **(8) to treat / treating** everyone with respect: human rights start with small, everyday actions.



Eleanor Roosevelt with the Declaration in Spanish, 1949.

C. Complete the sentences

Use the verb in parentheses with the correct pattern.

1. My parents never let me _____ (watch) TV after 9 p.m.
2. She promised _____ (not / tell) anyone about the surprise party.
3. The movie was so sad that I couldn't help _____ (cry).
4. The teacher reminded us _____ (bring) our ID cards to the exam.
5. I'm really looking forward to _____ (meet) your family.
6. I can't stand _____ (wait) in long lines.
7. He stopped _____ (smoke) two years ago, and he feels much better now.
8. On the way home, we stopped _____ (buy) some bread.
9. I regret _____ (not / listen) to my grandmother's advice.
10. Would you like _____ (come) to the concert with us?

D. Find the mistake

Some sentences are correct (✓). Correct the ones that are wrong.

1. My parents expect that I study medicine.
2. She suggested to go to the beach on Saturday.
3. The police made them to leave the building.
4. I'm used to waking up early.
5. He avoided to answer the question.
6. The school didn't allow us use our phones in class.
7. She is thinking about to move to Bogotá.
8. We decided not to travel this year.

E. Your turn: write about you

Complete these sentences with true information. Then **underline verb 2** and check its form.

1. In my free time, I enjoy … _____
2. This year, I hope … _____
3. When I was a child, my parents didn't let me … _____
4. My teachers always encouraged me … _____
5. I'll never forget … _____

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Exercise B: "Eleanor Roosevelt and United Nations Universal Declaration of Human Rights in Spanish text" (Nov. 1949), Wikimedia Commons, public domain. Diagrams and chart: created for this guide.

Answer key

A. -ING, TO or both?

- **-ING only:** enjoy, avoid, finish, keep
- **TO only:** decide, refuse, hope, afford
- **Both:** love, start

B. Choose the correct option

1. to live; **2.** to protect; **3.** to go; **4.** violating; **5.** reporting; **6.** to speak; **7.** volunteering; **8.** to treat

C. Complete the sentences

#	Answer	Why
1	**watch**	Pattern 4: let + object + base verb
2	**not to tell**	Pattern 2: promise + to (negative: not to)
3	**crying**	Pattern 1: can't help + -ING
4	**to bring**	Pattern 3: remind + object + to
5	**meeting**	Pattern 1: look forward to (preposition) + -ING
6	**waiting** or **to wait**	Pattern 5: both are correct
7	**smoking**	Pattern 6: stop + -ING = he doesn't smoke anymore
8	**to buy**	Pattern 6: stop + to = we paused in order to buy
9	**not listening**	Pattern 6: regret + -ING = sorry about the past
10	**to come**	Pattern 2: would like + to

D. Find the mistake

#	Correct version
1	My parents expect **me** **to study** medicine.
2	She suggested **going** to the beach on Saturday.
3	The police made them **leave** the building.
4	✓ Correct.
5	He avoided **answering** the question.
6	The school didn't allow us **to use** our phones in class.
7	She is thinking about **moving** to Bogotá.
8	✓ Correct.

E. Your turn (possible answers)

1. I enjoy **playing** soccer. **2.** I hope **to pass** all my courses. **3.** ...my parents didn't let me **stay** out late. **4.** ...encouraged me **to read** more. **5.** I'll never forget **meeting** my best friend.

> **How did you do?** If you made mistakes in one pattern, go back to that pattern in Part 2 and read the verb list again. Then try to write 3 new sentences of your own with those verbs.